

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-05-17

To the youth gathered at the five regional bahá'í

1 barcelona, berlin, bucharest, Saint Petersburg, and Wolverhampton

2 beloved friends,

during this past year, with the encouragement of the European Bahá'í

youth council, a new movement among this generation of Bahá'í youth

3 has been gathering momentum throughout the continent. like the swelling

4 of a tide, some waves may be but wavelets as yet, but the time for such an upsurge is here. Surely the successive impulses of training seminars, of the conference of National Bahá'í youth committees held in April, and now 181.12

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184 8 of these five continent-wide conferences, will reinforce the eagerness of the

185 youth to rise and seize the challenge to play their part in reshaping the life

186 of the peoples of the European continent.

187 it is but a century and a half since two young men sat in an upper room

188 of the city of Shiraz; one the manifestation of God revealing the first words

189 of God for this era, the other his first disciple. within the space of six years,

190 both had laid down their lives so that this outpouring of divine revelation

might quicken all humankind. by that time, hundreds and thousands of

191 eager hearts, men and women, old and young, rich and poor, learned and

192 illiterate, had arisen to welcome the breaking of the dawn of divine guid-

193 ance and champion the truth before the world.

Now we see that the world has become another world. As Bahá'u'lláh

194 has written: "mankind's ordered life hath been revolutionized through the

195 agency of this unique, this wondrous System—the like of which mortal eyes have never witnessed."

196 182-1

197 you have come together from lands which are troubled by many different
198 ills: ecological, economic, political, social, intellectual and, above all, moral
199 and spiritual. y ou are aware that some of your peers are desperately seeking
200 solutions and, too often alas, are driven to violent means to combat those
201 immediate evils which fill their vision. others turn aside, despairingly or
202 cynically from any thought that a remedy is possible. you know the solu-
203 tion, you have the vision, you have the guidance and you are the recipients of the
spiritual power which can enable you to triumph over all adversities and bring new life to
the youth of e urope.

204 To be young is not easy. There are so many calls on one's time and energy
205 because, not only are you summoned to perform the duties of the day, but also to
prepare yourselves for the tasks which will be yours during the remainder of your lives. in
weighing how to apportion your time and energy

206 to such a multitude of activities you can call upon the power of consulta-tion with
your parents, your friends, and the divinely created institutions of the b ahá'í administration.

207 Those of you who are at a point in your studies or careers where you can
208 devote a special period of service to the cause of god, may be able to re-
209 spond to the call of the youth council for an army of youth-year-of-service
210 volunteers to go out after these conferences to accelerate the winning of the

211 182-1. gwb, no. 70.1.182.2

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183 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

184 8goals of the Three year plan in europe. Those who cannot serve in this way
185 have other avenues of service in their own countries and abroad. for all of
186 you there is the opportunity and the need to present the Teachings of the
187 cause to all whom you meet, through your character, your behavior, your unity, your
deeds and your words, and to win their allegiance to the f aith.

may the hosts of the Supreme concourse rush to your aid, and may

188 bahá'u'lláh bless and guide every step you take for the advancement of his

189 cause.
190 we shall remember you all in our prayers in the h oly Shrines.
191 with loving b ahá'í greetings,
192 183

**Response to Concerns Raised by the U.S. National
Spiritual Assembly**

19 m ay 1994

The National Spiritual Assembly of the b ahá'ís of the u nited States

20 dear b ahá'í f riends,
21 we recall with much joy and deep gratitude to bahá'u'lláh your presence
22 in the holy land only a short while ago during the month of the fast.
23 your urgent request to which we acceded by meeting with all nine of your
24 members in intensive consultations over a period of three days—a new fact
25 of history in itself—initiated another phase in the evolution of your As-
26 sembly and reinforced the bonds that bind the American bahá'í community
27 to the world center of the faith. our hearts were touched by the candor,
28 courage, and sincerity with which your members presented your concerns,
29 as well as by the spirit of optimism you displayed despite the overwhelming
30 challenges and burdens which prompted your request for a meeting with us.
31 having considered the various points and queries you raised, we are now
32 able to respond to those which fall under the broad categories of teaching, relations
between your National Spiritual Assembly and the continental
33 counselors, and the functioning of your Assembly.

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185 85regarding your “ vision in Action” initiative, you reported evidences of a
186 tremendous response, some movement, and some expansion; furthermore,
187 the stimulus of the recent Atlanta conference spearheaded by the conti-

188 mental counselors caused a marked acceleration of activities. in sum, the
189 friends have seldom been more visibly active, but growth is slow; you feel
190 the community has for some time been on the threshold of a breakthrough
191 which remains elusive. The degeneration of society, as manifested by the
192 breakdown of moral standards and the alarming increase of violence, you feel, is
exerting a debilitating effect on the individual believer. you yearn for
193 a way to free the teaching potential which to a large extent is locked up in
194 the individual in the face of these dreadful circumstances.

we feel that an overanxiousness on your part about a breakthrough and

195 an undue worry over the state of society can be counterproductive. while
196 there are opportunities for greater growth than is occurring, neither your
197 Assembly nor the friends must burden themselves with feelings of failure at every
disappointment, for such feelings are self-fulfilling and can eas-ily cause stagnation in the
expansion of the cause. The tendency towards
198 frustration, sometimes induced by a desire for instant gratification, must be resisted
by an effort to gain deeper appreciation of the divine process. in
199 exhorting the individual concerning the spiritual obligation resting upon him “to
make of the mandate of teaching, so vitally binding upon all, the
200 all-pervading concern of his life,” Shoghi effendi said that “every bearer of
201 the message of bahá’u’lláh should consider it not only an obligation but a
202 privilege to scatter far and wide the seeds of his faith, and to rest content
203 in the abiding knowledge that whatever be the immediate response to that
204 message, and however inadequate the vehicle that conveyed it, the power
205 of its Author will, as he sees fit, enable those seeds to germinate, and in
206 circumstances which no one can foresee enrich the harvest which the labor

of his followers will gather.”

207 183-1 you may rest assured that your particularly
208 blessed community will not be denied a triumphant expansion if its mem-bers remain
constant and confident in their teaching activities.
209 paradoxical as it may seem, the prospects towards the breakthrough you
210 anticipate in the teaching field are conspicuous in the current, distressing
211 state of society. you must realize that the worse conditions become, the
212 more plentiful are the opportunities to teach the cause, the greater the de-

213 183-1. Adj, ¶78.183.3

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185 86gree of receptivity to the divine message. bahá'u'lláh certainly gave ample

186 foreknowledge about the radical, worldwide disturbance which his revela-

187 tion is creating as a part of the transition towards the unity and peace that

188 are the ultimate goal of his faith. your awareness of this inevitable transi-

189 tion should enable your members to detach themselves from the debilitating
emotions aroused by the turmoil which characterizes this process and to

190 equip your Assembly as the highest governing body of the bahá'í commu-

191 nity in the united States to demonstrate to the friends a confident outlook,

192 which the persistence and vigor of their teaching activities will fully justify.

Such detachment as exemplified by your Assembly and practiced by

193 the friends throughout the community will, moreover, signify a spiritual

achievement which was anticipated by Shoghi effendi in his warning to

194 your community, when he said: "The glowing tributes, so repeatedly and

195 deservedly paid to the capacity, the spirit, the conduct, and the high rank,

196 of the American believers, both individually and as an organic commu-nity, must,
under no circumstances, be confounded with the characteristics and nature of the people
from which god has raised them up." in other

197 words, by the attainment of a "sharp distinction between that community and that
people," you and the friends who rely upon your guidance will recognize that American
society cannot be exempted from the rigors and consequences of the transition affecting all
the world.

198 183-2

199 painful as may be the decadent scene, deep as is your sympathy for those

200 who suffer from the terrible decline of society, you must see the possibilities

201 which are thus provided for augmenting the healing forces of an emerg-

ing world order. Shoghi effendi advised the North American community

202 plainly in this regard. "The opportunities which the turmoil of the present age
presents, with all the sorrows which it evokes, the fears which it excites,

203 the disillusionment which it produces, the perplexities which it creates, the

204 indignation which it arouses, the revolt which it provokes, the grievances it engenders, the spirit of restless search which it awakens, must," he asserted, "be exploited for the purpose of spreading far and wide the knowledge of

205 the redemptive power of the faith of bahá'u'lláh, and for enlisting fresh

recruits in the ever-swelling army of his followers."

206 183-3

207 183-2. Adj, ¶27, 28.

208 183-3. Adj, ¶71.183.6

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185 87commenting further on the global spectacle of upheavals, cataclysms and

186 tribulations which the worsening affairs of humanity evoke at the impending

approach of the kingdom of god on earth, Shoghi effendi addressed

187 these words of insight and encouragement to the North American friends:

188 "far from yielding in their resolve, far from growing oblivious of their task,

189 they should, at no time, however much buffeted by circumstances, forget

190 that the synchronization of such world-shaking crises with the progressive

191 unfoldment and fruition of their divinely appointed task is itself the work of providence, the design of an inscrutable wisdom, and the purpose of an

192 all-compelling will, a will that directs and controls, in its own mysterious

193 way, both the fortunes of the faith and the destinies of men. Such simultaneous

194 processes of rise and of fall, of integration and of disintegration, of order and chaos, with their continuous and reciprocal reactions on each

195 other, are but aspects of a greater plan, one and indivisible, whose Source

196 is god, whose author is bahá'u'lláh, the theatre of whose operations is the

197 entire planet, and whose ultimate objectives are the unity of the human race

and the peace of all mankind."

198 183-4

moreover, the beloved guardian felt that: "reflections such as these

199 should steel the resolve of the entire bahá'í community, should dissipate

200 their forebodings, and arouse them to rededicate themselves to every single provision of that divine charter whose outline has been delineated for

them by the pen of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá.”

201 183-5 by being attuned to this divine per-
202 spective, your Assembly will be able to assist the friends to see that they will
203 not merely be able to cope with the alarming incidents of social decline they
204 are daily witnessing, but even better than that, they will be inspired to arise with
renewed vision to recruit to bahá’í membership an increasing number

of men and women whose minds and hearts are ready to respond to the

205 divine message and who will join them in dispelling the bewilderment and
206 despair gripping their fellow citizens and undermining the structure of their
207 country.
208 it is also vital for your Assembly to keep in mind that the mental anguish
209 which the prevailing situation induces can and must be overcome through prayer
and a conscious attention to teaching the cause and living the bahá’í

210 life with a world-embracing vision. certainly, the members of such a well

211 183-4. Adj, ¶101.

212 183-5. Adj, ¶102.183.8

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185 88established community as yours, one enjoying the special favors providen-
186 tially conferred upon it by the Tablets of the divine plan, do realize the

187 urgency and seriousness of their task. Surely they see with what patient endurance
the dear friends in the cradle of the faith are meeting their god-

188 given challenges even to the extent of sacrificing their life’s blood so that the world
may become a better place. undoubtedly, the highly esteemed

189 American believers, who bear the designation “spiritual descendants of the
dawn-breakers,”

190 183-6 know quite well that they must now seize their chance

191 at this critical time to prove their own capacity to endure that living sacrifice

192 which, as Shoghi effendi said, in contrast to dying, is required of them if

193 they are to fulfill the glorious destiny forecast for them in the scriptures

194 of our faith. may they be granted the celestial strength to pass, over and

195 over again, the mental tests which 'Abdu'l-b ahá promised he would send to
196 them to purify them, thus enabling them to achieve their divinely conferred potential
as a force for change in the world.
197 in the arena of teaching, your indispensable terms of reference and the
198 unerring resource to which you have ready access are the master's Tablets
199 of the divine plan. They invest your community with extraordinary pow-
200 ers shared by your sister community in canada. it is in reacquainting the
201 American friends with the special mission, both at home and abroad, as-
202 signed to them in these seminal and timeless documents, and in relating
203 their contents to current conditions, that you will find the key to the revital-ization of
the teaching work and the winning of outstanding victories on the home front. in this effort
you will be powerfully aided by the explanations
204 provided in the letters of our dear guardian, such as The Advent of Divine
205 Justice, "The challenging requirements of the present hour," "American

bahá'ís in the Time of world peril."

206 183-7 we have every confidence that, to-
207 gether with the continental counselors and the Auxiliary board members,
208 you can discover the way further to release the enormous energies of the friends and
to intensify the zeal which they have so splendidly displayed in the teaching field on so
many occasions in the past.

209 183-6. Adj, ¶15.

210 183-7 . The latter two letters can be found in cf, pp. 4-37 and 122-32,
respectively.183.11

211 1993-1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

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212 we were very pleased by the sense you conveyed of an ever-closer rela-

tionship between your Assembly and the continental counselors, and we

213 were even more deeply impressed by your eagerness to know how you might
214 strengthen this relationship. A beginning towards achieving your desire would be for
you to obtain an integrated understanding of the counselors'
215 responsibilities and sphere of action in relation to your own.

As you know, a distinguishing feature of the Administrative order is

216 the existence of elected institutions, on the one hand, which function corporately
with vested legislative, executive and judicial powers, and of appointed, eminent and
devoted believers, on the other hand, who function

217 primarily as individuals for the specific purposes of protecting and propa-
218 gating the faith under the guidance of the head of the faith. The two sets
219 of institutions collaborate in their functions so as to ensure the progress of
220 the cause. you are undoubtedly aware of the previous exposition of this
221 subject; however, we offer the following comments to assist your further
222 understanding of the matter.

The continental boards of counselors and the National Spiritual As-

223 semblies share in the functions of propagation and protection, but the counselors
specialize in these functions from a different level and in a different manner. from a
continental vantage point, the counselors bring a

224 perspective to their functions which, when offered to a National Assembly
225 in the form of counsel, advice, recommendations, suggestions or commen-
226 tary, enriches the latter's understanding, acquaints it with a broader experience than
its own, and encourages it to maintain a world-embracing vision.

227 An aspect of the difference in the manner of functioning of the counsel-
228 ors derives from the instructions given in the will and Testament of 'Abdu'l-
229 bahá to the hands of the cause of god, the extension into the future of
230 whose functions of protection and propagation is the responsibility of the
231 assist the head of the faith to broaden the base, foster the strength and
232 ensure the security of the National Spiritual Assemblies and the institu-
233 tions and communities under their jurisdiction. Through their Auxiliary
234 boards, the continental counselors spread the benefits of their functions to
235 the local Spiritual Assemblies and the grassroots of the community. These
236 functions are shaped by their obligations, in the words of the will and Tes-
237 tament, "to diffuse the divine fragrances, to edify the souls of men, to 183.12

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184 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

185 90promote learning, to improve the character of all men and to be, at all times
186 and under all conditions, sanctified and detached from earthly things.”183-8
187 it can be seen, then, that through their work in propagating and protecting
188 the faith, the counselors play a major role in knitting and bolstering the
189 entire fabric of the b ahá’í community.

190 The flexibility and speed with which the counselors and their Auxiliary

board members can respond to a perceived need in the community—such

191 as a need for encouragement, explanation of plans, deepening in the Teach-
192 ings, protection of the covenant—are elements of their functioning which
193 distinguish them from Spiritual Assemblies; this flexibility enables them to operate as
occasions demand, whether it is in giving counsel at a meeting, or
194 advising an individual in private, or helping the friends to understand and
195 obey a ruling of the Spiritual Assembly, or dealing with issues of the cov-
196 enant. in such different modes these officers of the faith are able to draw
197 attention to relevant Texts, to impart information, explore situations, and acquaint
themselves with conditions in ways not possible to a Spiritual As-sembly but important to
the success of its plans. They are able then to share with Spiritual Assemblies, as deemed
necessary, ideas, analyses, perceptions
198 and advice which inevitably enhance the ability of these Assemblies to serve

their communities. They thus assist Assemblies to mature. where local

199 Assemblies are new or weak, Auxiliary board members help them to under-
200 stand their functions, encourage them to organize their work, and rally the
201 local believers in support of their Assemblies’ initiatives.

202 Through the various modes of their activities, the counselors aided by
203 their Auxiliary boards spark and buttress the growth and development of
204 Spiritual Assemblies and local and national communities. with this per-
205 spective, Shoghi effendi’s regarding of the Auxiliary board members as “a

prop and mainstay to the often overworked and overburdened National

206 Spiritual Assemblies” becomes clear. The indispensability of the involve-
207 ment of continental counselors and Auxiliary board members in the plan-
208 ning stages of the teaching work and the benefits of acquainting them with

209 the hopes and concerns of National Spiritual Assemblies and of seeking their advice
are also obvious.

210 with the opening of the fourth epoch of the formative Age, a procedure

211 was activated by which the goals of national plans are formulated in joint
consultations of National Spiritual Assemblies and continental counselors.

212 183-8. w T, p. 13.183.16

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184 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

185 91it initiated a new phase in the maturation of the Administrative order. This

186 development ensures two significant benefits in particular: it enables each

187 institution to draw on the experiences and insights particular to the other,

188 thereby making available to the planning process two distinct channels of
information from two levels of bahá'í administration; and it also assures to

189 the counselors a necessary familiarity with the background, rationale, and

190 content of national plans, which as a matter of principle they are expected to support.
both institutions obtain strength from such collaboration, and

191 we are particularly pleased that the designing of the Three year plan in

192 the united States followed a pattern which involved the two arms of the

193 administration in the manner you described to us.

194 while the counselors and their Auxiliary boards, in addition to the dis-

195 charge of their specific responsibilities, will support the initiatives adopted

196 by a National Spiritual Assembly, the Assembly should recognize that the

197 counselors must be free to determine, according to their own best judg-ment, in what
manner that support will be given. There is a great difference between the functions of
national committees and Auxiliary board members

198 in this respect. whereas the committees may be required by the Assembly

199 to follow particular procedures, Auxiliary board members are not similarly

200 bound; yet they should not act in a manner that undermines the operations of the
National Assembly or its agencies. This does not mean that Auxil-

201 iary board members may not decide, upon request or not, to participate in

202 the execution of a particular program or educational project devised by a

203 national committee, or even to contribute towards the conceptualization

204 and fruition of the project. it does mean, however, that their prerogative to
205 proceed within a wider latitude than that accessible to the national commit-
206 tee should be respected.

by working at the grassroots of the community, an Auxiliary board

207 member is often able to satisfy a need not being met by any national or local program,
but which if dealt with by the Auxiliary board member will

208 better equip the local friends to achieve the established goals of the com-munity. Such
a flexibility on the part of the Auxiliary board member in

209 dealing with immediate situations, such a freedom for independent action, should be
taken for granted by all concerned. however, a pattern of activity

210 on the part of the Auxiliary board member, or even of a counselor, which

211 appears to the National Assembly to be seriously diverting attention from the
adopted plans of the community should unhesitatingly be made a mat-ter for remedial
consultation with the counselor.183.19

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184 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

185 92The counselors are members of a continental, as distinct from a na-

186 tional, institution, and they occupy a rank higher than that of the National

187 Spiritual Assembly. Apart from any other consideration, their rank is, in a

188 practical sense, a functional necessity if these officers of the faith are to be

189 accorded freedom of the community at all levels and their advice and other functions
are to be taken seriously. we have said in an earlier letter that "the

190 existence of institutions of such exalted rank, comprising individuals who play such a
vital role, who yet have no legislative, administrative or judicial authority, and are entirely
devoid of priestly functions or the right to make authoritative interpretations, is a feature of
bahá'í administration unparal-

leled in the religions of the past."

191 183-9 it is a difficult concept to grasp. but

192 with the passage of time since the first contingent of continental counsel-

193 ors was appointed, much understanding has surely been acquired.

194 Shoghi effendi stated categorically to your Assembly: "There can be no

195 conflict of authority, no duality under any form or circumstances in any sphere of
bahá'í jurisdiction whether local, national or international."

196 183-10

197 The authority of a National Assembly is therefore not diminished but,
 198 rather, enhanced by the existence of the continental counselors, who are
 199 duty bound by the very character of their responsibilities as protectors of
 200 the faith to uphold the rank and to support the authority of Spiritual As-
 201 semblies. Similarly, the National Assembly must, on the basis of principle
 202 and in its own best interest, ensure that counselors and Auxiliary board
 203 members are not hampered in carrying out their sacred responsibilities and
 204 that their right and freedom to function are upheld.

205 The attitude of these two institutions towards each other should be mo-
 206 tivated not merely by a legalistic application of the rules of their functional
 relationship. far more is required, for they must, in the first place, approach
 207 their joint responsibilities within the framework of the spiritual requisites
 208 for all successful bahá'í relationships. where love, respect and courtesy are

genuinely and mutually expressed, estrangement finds no accommodation

209 and problems become soluble challenges. bahá'u'lláh's admonition is highly
 210 instructive in this regard; he says: "Abase not the station of the learned in
 211 bahá and belittle not the rank of such rulers as administer justice amidst
 you."

212 183-11

213 183-9. muhj, no. 111.14.

214 183-10. dg, p. 50.183-11. Tb, p. 138.183.21

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185 9Achieving a closer and more effective relationship between you and the
 186 continental counselors will depend on the cultivation of an incrementally
 187 harmonious attitude and on an openness in your dealings with them which
 188 this attitude will certainly facilitate. The relationship between you should be one of
 fellowship informed with a sense of respect but devoid of the rigid formalities associated
 with so many social organizations. when you

189 have doubts and concerns about your own plans, confide in the counselors;

190 when something they do causes you worry, talk to them in the proper spirit of bahá'í
consultation. remember that they, like yourselves, are burdened

191 with the work of the cause and are beset with many concerns in its service,

192 and they need your sympathetic understanding of the challenges they face. open
your hearts and your minds to them; regard them as your confidants,

your loving friends. And be ever ready to extend to them your hand in

193 support.

194 The existence of a loving, trusting and informal atmosphere in your deal-
195 ings with the counselors should not, however, be allowed to relax adherence
196 to the rules governing the working relationship between the continental
197 board of counselors and their Auxiliary boards, on the one hand, and the
198 National Spiritual Assembly and its committees, on the other. These mat-
199 ters are explained in detail in our letter of 1 october 1969, which you have
200 published.

201 183-12

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we now wish to address the manner of your functioning as a National

202 Spiritual Assembly. your analysis of the situation identified the issues of im-
203 mediate concern about the national administration of the faith, such issues

204 as: overcentralization, particularly with regard to the administration of the teaching
work; your fear that you may be exercising a level of administrative control that may be
stifling individual initiative throughout the country;

205 and the relation of your Assembly to the community.

206 you live in a society caught in the tightening grip of moral decadence on

207 a vast scale. but this should come as no surprise to you. it is the unavoid-

208 able consequence of a pervasive godlessness; its symptoms and repercussions were
described in painful detail by Shoghi effendi in several of his letters to

209 183-12. See muhj, no. 72.183.24

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184 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

185 9the western friends. inevitably, the American bahá'í community is affected
186 by this condition to some extent. The corrosive influence of an overbearing
187 and rampant secularization is infecting the style of administration of the
188 faith in your community and threatening to undermine its efficacy.

The aggressiveness and competitiveness which animate a dominantly

189 capitalist culture; the partisanship inherent in a fervidly democratic system;
190 the suspicion of public-policy institutions and the skepticism towards estab-
191 lished authority ingrained in the political attitude of the people and which trace their
origins to the genesis of American society; the cynical disregard of the moderating principles
and rules of civilized human relationships re-
192 sulting from an excessive liberalism and its immoral consequences—such
193 unsavory characteristics inform entrenched habits of American life, which
imperceptibly at first but more obviously in the long run have come to exert
194 too great a sway over the manner of management of the bahá'í community
195 and over the behavior of portions of its rank and file in relation to the
196 cause. This unwholesome influence must be arrested by immediate, delib-erate
effort—an effort which must surely begin within your Assembly itself.
197 further accommodation of it will severely impede the progress of your com-
198 munity, despite the abundant possibilities of an imminent breakthrough.
199 it was due to this concern in particular that we anxiously welcomed your
200 request for a meeting with us.

201 The guarantee of well-being and success in all your endeavors to serve the
202 cause of god can be stated in one word: unity. it is the alpha and omega
203 of all bahá'í objectives. Among the first admonitions addressed to National
204 Spiritual Assemblies by Shoghi effendi was the following assertion: “i t is, i
205 firmly believe, of the utmost urgent importance that, with unity of purpose and
action firmly established in our midst, and with every trace of animos-ity and mistrust of the
past banished from our hearts, we should form one
206 united front, and combat, wisely and tactfully, every force that might darken
207 the spirit of the movement, cause division in its ranks, and narrow it by
208 dogmatic and sectarian belief.” he then stated that “it is primarily upon the
209 elected members of the National Spiritual Assemblies throughout the bahá'í

210 world that this highly important duty devolves," warning that, "should such a
representative and responsible body fail to realize this fundamental requisite for all
successful achievement, the whole structure is sure to crumble."

211 183-13

212 183-13. bA, pp. 45, 46.183.28

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184 1993-1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

185 95unity within the Assembly itself is, of course, of immediate importance

186 to the wider unity your actions are intended to foster and sustain. At no

time can any member of your Assembly afford to be unmindful of this

187 basic requirement nor neglect to work towards upholding it. of particular

188 relevance is the attitude that the members adopt towards their membership on that
exalted body. There needs to be a recognition on their part of the

189 Assembly's spiritual character and a feeling in their hearts of respect for the

190 institution based upon a perception of it as something beyond or apart from
themselves, as a sacred entity whose powers they have the privilege to engage and canalize
by coming together in harmony and acting in accordance with

191 divinely revealed principles. with such a perspective the members will be

192 able better to acquire an appropriate posture in relation to the Assembly

193 itself, to appreciate their role as T rustees of the merciful and to counteract

194 any impression that they have assumed ownership and control of the insti-tution in
the manner of major stockholders of a business enterprise.

195 Also relevant to effecting unity is the attitude of the friends, whether

196 serving on any Assembly or not, towards the exercise of authority in the

197 bahá'í community. people generally tend to be suspicious of those in au-

198 thority. The reason is not difficult to understand, since human history is

199 replete with examples of the disastrous misuse of authority and power. A reversal of
this tendency is not easily achievable, but the bahá'í friends must

200 be freed of suspicion towards their institutions if the wheels of progress are to turn
with uninterrupted speed. A rigorous discipline of thought and ac-tion on the part of both
the friends and the National Assembly will succeed

201 in meeting this challenge; both must live up to their responsibilities in this

202 regard by recognizing some fundamental realities.

The oneness of humanity, which is the primary principle and ultimate

203 goal of the cause of bahá'u'lláh, implies, as Shoghi effendi said, an “or-
ganic change in the structure of present-day society.”

204 183-14 So fundamental
205 a change in the structural conception of society must also imply a new
206 pattern for the administration of community affairs in a bahá'í context. The
207 insights offered by the beloved guardian, as conveyed by his secretary in a
208 letter dated 14 October 1941, shed light on this critical subject:

209 183-14. wob, p. 43.183.30

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184 m e S a g e f r o m T h e u n i v e r s a l h o u s e o f j u s t i c e

96The friends must never mistake the bahá'í administration for an

185 end in itself. it is merely the instrument of the spirit of the faith. This

cause is a cause which god has revealed to humanity as a whole. it is

designed to benefit the entire human race, and the only way it can do

186 this is to reform the community life of mankind, as well as seeking to regenerate the
individual. The bahá'í Administration is only the first

187 shaping of what in future will come to be the social life and laws of community
living.

188 183-15

189 Shoghi effendi's advice to an individual in another instance provides a fur-

190 ther perspective: “h e urges you to do all you can to promote unity and love

amongst the members of the community there, as this seems to be their

191 greatest need. So often young communities, in their desire to administer the cause,
lose sight of the fact that these spiritual relationships are far more important and
fundamental than the rules and regulations which must gov-

ern the conduct of community affairs.”

192 183-16

193 it can therefore be deduced that the importance of the bahá'í administra-

194 tion is its value in serving as a facilitator of the emergence and maintenance of
community life in a wholly new mode, and in catering to the require-

195 ments of the spiritual relationships which flow from love and unity among the
196 friends. This touches upon a distinguishing characteristic of bahá'í life

197 which such spiritual relationships foster, namely, the spirit of servitude to
198 god, expressed in service to the cause, to the friends and to humanity as a
199 whole. The attitude of the individual as a servant, an attitude preeminently
200 exemplified in the life and person of 'Abdu'l-bahá, is a dynamic that perme-
201 ates the activities of the faith; it acquires collective, transformative force in
202 the normal functioning of a community. in this regard, the institutions of
203 the faith stand as channels for the promotion of this salient characteristic. it
204 is in this framework that the concepts of rulership and leadership, authority
205 and power are properly understood and actualized.

206 The appearance of a united, firmly based and self-sustaining community
207 must be a major goal of a Spiritual Assembly. composed of a membership
208 reflecting a diversity of personalities, talents, abilities and interests, such a
209 community requires a level of internal interaction between the Assembly

183-15. lg, no. 277 .

183-16. lg, no. 1344.183.32a

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185 97and the body of the believers based on a commonly recognized commitment
186 to service, and in which a sense of partnership based on appreciation of
187 each other's distinctive sphere of action is fully recognized and unfailingly
188 upheld, and no semblance of a dichotomy between the two appears. in such

189 a community leadership is that expression of service by which the Spiritual Assembly
invites and encourages the use of the manifold talents and abili-

190 ties with which the community is endowed, and stimulates and guides the

191 diverse elements of the community towards goals and strategies by which the effects
of a coherent force for progress can be realized.

192 The maintenance of a climate of love and unity depends largely upon the

193 feeling among the individuals composing the community that the Assembly is a part
of themselves, that their cooperative interactions with that divinely ordained body allow
them a fair latitude for initiative and that the quality

194 of their relationships with both the institution and their fellow believers
 195 encourages a spirit of enterprise invigorated by an awareness of the revolutionizing
 purpose of bahá'u'lláh's revelation, by a consciousness of the
 196 high privilege of their being associated with efforts to realize that purpose,
 197 and by a consequent, ever-present sense of joy. in such a climate, the com-
 198 munity is transformed from being the mere sum of its parts to assuming a
 199 wholly new personality as an entity in which its members blend without losing their
 individual uniqueness. The possibilities for manifesting such a
 200 transformation exist most immediately at the local level, but it is a major
 201 responsibility of the National Assembly to nurture the conditions in which they may
 flourish.
 202 The authority to direct the affairs of the faith locally, nationally and
 203 internationally, is divinely conferred on elected institutions. however, the
 204 power to accomplish the tasks of the community resides primarily in the mass of the
 believers. The authority of the institutions is an irrevocable
 205 necessity for the progress of humanity; its exercise is an art to be mastered.
 206 The power of action in the believers is unlocked at the level of individual initiative
 and surges at the level of collective volition. in its potential, this
 207 mass power, this mix of individual potentialities, exists in a malleable form
 208 susceptible to the multiple reactions of individuals to the sundry influences
 209 at work in the world. To realize its highest purpose, this power needs to express itself
 through orderly avenues of activity. even though individuals
 210 may strive to be guided in their actions by their personal understanding of the divine
 Texts, and much can be accomplished thereby, such actions,
 211 untempered by the overall direction provided by authorized institutions, are 183.35
 183 36
 184 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 185 98incapable of attaining the thrust necessary for the unencumbered advance-
 186 ment of civilization.
 187 individual initiative is a preeminent aspect of this power; it is therefore
 188 a major responsibility of the institutions to safeguard and stimulate it. Similarly, it is
 important for individuals to recognize and accept that the institutions must act as a guiding
 and moderating influence on the march of
 189 civilization. in this sense, the divine requirement that individuals obey the

190 decisions of their Assemblies can clearly be seen as being indispensable to
191 the progress of society. indeed, individuals must not be abandoned entirely
192 to their own devices with respect to the welfare of society as a whole, neither
193 should they be stifled by the assumption of a dictatorial posture by members
194 of the institutions.

195 The successful exercise of authority in the bahá'í community implies the
196 recognition of separate but mutually reinforcing rights and responsibilities between
the institutions and the friends in general, a recognition that in turn welcomes the need for
cooperation between these two interactive forces of society. As was stated in advice given by
Shoghi effendi: "The individuals

197 and assemblies must learn to cooperate, and to cooperate intelligently, if they desire
to adequately discharge their duties and obligations towards the faith. And no such
cooperation is possible without mutual confidence and

trust."

198 183-17

199 direction comes from Assembly decisions, but its effectiveness depends
200 not only on the clarity with which it is given but also on a number of
201 spiritual and moral factors which must be blended in the general attitude of
202 the individual believers, on the one hand, and the manner and style of the
functioning of the Assembly, on the other. The following advice of Shoghi effendi, addressed
in an early letter to the western friends, deals with these

203 two aspects:

let us also bear in mind that the keynote to the cause of god is not

204 dictatorial authority, but humble fellowship, not arbitrary power, but
205 the spirit of frank and loving consultation. Nothing short of the spirit

of a true bahá'í can hope to reconcile the principles of mercy and

206 justice, of freedom and submission, of the sanctity of the right of the

207 183-17 . lgA, p. 9.183.37

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184 1993-1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

185 99individual and of self-surrender, of vigilance, discretion and prudence

186 on the one hand and fellowship, candor and courage on the other.

The duties of those whom the friends have freely and conscien-

187 tiously elected as their representatives are no less vital and binding than the obligations of those who have chosen them. Their function is not to dictate, but to consult, and consult not only among themselves,

but as much as possible with the friends whom they represent. They

188 must regard themselves in no other light but that of chosen instruments for a more efficient and dignified presentation of the cause of

god. They should never be led to suppose that they are the central

189 ornaments of the body of the cause, intrinsically superior to others in

190 capacity or merit, and sole promoters of its teachings and principles. They should approach their task with extreme humility, and endeavor

by their open-mindedness, their high sense of justice and duty, their

191 candor, their modesty, their entire devotion to the welfare and in-terests of the friends, the cause, and humanity, to win not only the

confidence and the genuine support and respect of those whom they

192 should serve, but also their esteem and real affection.

193 183-18

194 These instructions of the beloved guardian get to the very heart of what

195 must be more deeply internalized by the members of your Assembly at this time. we repeat for emphasis the terms "extreme humility," "open-mind-

edness," "candor," "modesty"; and we underscore the openness which is

196 implicit in candor, because the cooperation which must be fostered between your Assembly and the friends will depend significantly on the degree to

197 which, with wise discretion, you share your concerns with the community.

198 your greatest opportunity for this is the annual National convention, when

199 the representatives of the entire community come together to consult with you. it is not sufficient that you give only good news and encouraging sta-

200 tistics to the delegates. do as Shoghi effendi advised you: "b anishing every

201 vestige of secrecy, of undue reticence, of dictatorial aloofness, from their midst, they should radiantly and abundantly unfold to the eyes of the del-

202 egates, by whom they are elected, their plans, their hopes, and their cares.

203 They should familiarize the delegates with the various matters that will have

204 183-18. bA, pp. 63-64.183.39b

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185 00to be considered in the current year, and calmly and conscientiously study

and weigh the opinions and judgments of the delegates.”183-19

186 even if the delegates find themselves unable to offer useful recommenda-

187 tions toward the resolution of particular issues, by your bringing them into

188 your confidence, they will develop an appreciation, as would be impos-

189 sible otherwise, of the serious matters confronting the cause. with this

190 understanding, they will be equipped to assist the community to respond effectively
to your decisions, no matter how challenging these may turn out

191 to be. moreover, it will relieve you of any overwhelming sense of burden

192 to know that such a responsible body of believers shares your innermost

193 concerns; and even more than that, the effect of your openness will be to strengthen
the delegates’ support of your authority, which it is their sacred

194 duty to give. besides, as it is neither possible nor practicable for your As-

195 sembly to meet with all the believers, nor for the members to be constantly

196 traveling throughout the community, the friends’ feeling that you are re-

197 mote can be ameliorated, though not entirely removed, by the effectiveness

198 of your interactions with the delegates.

199 in your openness and candor you will, no doubt, avoid ineptitudes that

200 pass as norms in the freedom of speech practiced in your nation. in a society

201 where “telling it like it is” employs a style of expression which robs language of its
decorum, and in a time when stridency is commonly presumed to be a quality of leadership,
candor is crass, and authority speaks in a loud and vulgar voice. people are frequently
obliged to receive direction from their

202 leaders in such disrespectful modes; this is a reason for resentment and sus-picion
towards those in authority. by contrast, bahá’í institutions have the

203 task of accustoming the friends to recognizing the expression of authority

204 in language at a moderate pitch.

205 it would be impossible to overestimate the obligation resting upon you to

206 refine your dealings with the community in the ways already described. you

207 cannot at any time afford to forget that the manner of the use of authority is critical to
the success of your work. with this in mind, you must also

208 attend seriously to the behavior of those, more particularly your officers,

209 who must of necessity act on your behalf in carrying out your decisions and
conveying your instructions to others. further, it is sometimes the case

210 that staff members at your National center, in their eagerness to be exactly

211 183-19. bA, p. 79.183.41

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185 01and completely obedient, carry out the instruction of your Assembly with

186 a sharpness of manner and tone that hurts people and provokes resentment

187 against the very body the staff are striving to serve with loyalty and devotion.

188 The staff should be sensitized to the situation and made to realize, through your
loving and persistent guidance, that the spiritual requisites for good and respectful relations
with others must be conscientiously applied in their

189 interactions with the friends because to do so is not only virtuous in itself

190 but will also minimize the incidence of bad feeling towards your Assembly.

191 The temperament of authority in the administration of justice varies ac-

192 cording to the degree of the gravity of each case. Some cases require that

193 the Assembly take action that is firm or drastic. even so, Assembly members

194 have always to be mindful that the authority they wield must in general

195 be expressed with love, humility and a genuine respect for others. Thus

196 exercised, authority strikes a natural note and accords with that which is

197 acceptable to spiritually attuned and fair-minded souls. The following guid-ance of
Shoghi effendi, as conveyed by his secretary, is especially relevant:

198 “The administrators of the faith of god must be like unto shepherds. Their

199 aim should be to dispel all the doubts, misunderstandings and harmful dif-ferences
which may arise in the community of the believers. And this they can adequately achieve
provided they are motivated by a true sense of love for their fellow-brethren coupled with
firm determination to act with justice

in all cases which are submitted to them for their consideration.”

200 183-20

201 do clearly bear in mind that our emphasis of the spiritual requisites of
202 your functioning is not a mere expression of pious idealism. far, far from it.
203 Their exclusion from public discourse and from the considerations of world
204 leaders largely accounts for the current state of society. indeed, they are as
205 practical in effect as they are spiritual in essence. employ them consciously,
206 constantly, confidently; and see how your actions will attract the confirma-
207 tions of the h oly Spirit in the response of the community.

208 As to your worry about overcontrolling the friends: by appreciating the
209 nature of the power of action which they possess, you will be able to gauge
210 how best to guide and direct them. A wide latitude for action must be al-

lowed them, which means that a large margin for mistakes must also be

allowed. your National Assembly and the local Assemblies must not re-

211 act automatically to every mistake, but distinguish between those that are

212 183-20. lg, no. 119.183.44

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185 02self-correcting with the passage of time and do no particular harm to the

186 community and those which require Assembly intervention. related to this

187 is the tendency of the friends to criticize each other at the slightest provoca-tion,
whereas the Teachings call upon them to encourage each other. Such tendencies are of course
motivated by a deep love for the faith, a desire to

188 see it free of any flaw. but human beings are not perfect. The local As-

189 semblies and the friends must be helped through your example and through loving
counsel to refrain from such a pattern of criticism, which stunts the growth and development
of the community. you should also be fearful of

190 laying down too many rules and regulations. The cause is not so fragile

191 that a degree of mistakes cannot be tolerated. when you feel that certain

192 actions may become trends with harmful consequences, you may, instead of making
a new rule, discuss the matter with the counselors, enlisting

193 their support in educating the friends in a manner that will improve their
understanding and their conduct.

A new burst of energy would accrue to the operation of the Three year

194 plan if the friends, both individually and collectively, could feel a greater
195 sense of freedom to engage in a wide range of activities originating with themselves.
even if you are doing nothing deliberately to discourage such
196 freedom, their accumulated impression of institutional disapproval, how-ever
derived, and their fear of criticism are, to a considerable extent, in-
197 hibiting their exercise of initiative. At this exact time in history when the
198 peoples of the world are weighed down with soul-crushing difficulties and the
shadow of despair threatens to eclipse the light of hope, there must
199 be revived among the individual believers a sense of mission, a feeling of
200 empowerment to minister to the urgent need of humanity for guidance and thus to
win victories for the faith in their own sphere of life. The com-
201 munity as a whole should be involved in efforts to resolve such issues. A
202 single answer would, of course, be inadequate, there being so many diverse
203 elements and interests in the community. These matters require not only your own
independent consultation but consultation with the counselors
204 as well. Although Spiritual Assemblies are good at specifying goals, they
205 have not yet mastered the art of making use of the talents of individuals
206 and rousing the mass of the friends to action in fulfillment of such goals. removing
this deficiency would be a mark of the maturation of these insti-
207 tutions. may your Assembly lead the way.

208 A further decentralization of the national administration would increase
209 the possibility of loosening control at the top and encouraging the involve-183.47

183 48

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185 Oment of individuals in the work of the community at the grassroots. we
186 therefore welcome your intention to take such action. however, you may
187 wish to do this in incremental steps rather than in one sweeping motion.
188 The matter is left entirely to your judgment. it may encourage you to know
189 that in a few countries where the challenge of administering the teach-ing work and
providing other administrative services assumed formidable
190 proportions, various approaches have been used to achieve a measure of
191 decentralization. A detailed description of some of these approaches will be sent to
you separately.

* * *

192 having said all the foregoing, we pause to assure you of our full aware-
193 ness of the great burdens you carry and of the ceaseless calls upon you to render
services in the absence of adequate resources. do not despair. your

capacity to respond will match any challenge that may confront you in

194 these troubled times; you have only to act on principle. your community's
195 past has been glorious; its future is great beyond calculation. The divine
196 promises to your community are certain; the blessings of bahá'u'lláh are
197 assured as you strive to fulfill his purpose. The wings of the beloved mas-
198 ter remain spread over you that you may succeed in discharging the tasks he has
especially entrusted to your care. And our love ever surrounds you

and your cherished community, growing stronger at every moment. Step

199 forward then to meet the requirements of the hour with undiminished hope
200 and confidence.

201 The power released by bahá'u'lláh works at a quickening pace, speeding
202 the processes of change which must usher in the new order he proclaimed.

203 The declining state of society demonstrates it, the global yearning for new solutions
to human problems confirms it. much is at stake: the fortunes of

204 humankind hang precariously in the balance. The bahá'í community bears
205 grave responsibilities toward the near and far future as movement towards
206 the lesser peace accelerates. Now is the time for the friends to seize new
207 opportunities to extend the range and influence of the faith, to reach a new

208 level of action in expanding the community and fortifying its foundations. it is indeed
time for audacious action undeterred by a fear of mistakes, fired

209 by the urgency of ministering to the pressing needs of humanity. will the
210 American bahá'í community not see its chance to meet the challenge? will 183.49

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184 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

185 O its members not once again blaze a trail that can set in motion a myriad

186 victories?

our ardent petition at the holy Threshold is that the response of the

champion-builders of the New world order will be immediate, whole-

187 hearted and abundantly confirmed.

188 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

189 184

Availability of Electronic Versions of Sacred Writings

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]